Net-Zero Smart Energy Zones: A Spatio-Temporal Machine Learning and Simulation-Based Optimization Framework for Indian Smart Grids

Sudipta Sugyan Sahu
Dept. of CSE
Government College of Engineering Kalahandi
Bhawanipatna, India
sudiptsugyansahu@gcekbpatna.ac.in

Gopal Behera
Dept. of CSE
Government College of Engineering Kalahandi
Bhawanipatna, India
gbehera@gcekbpatna.ac.in

Om Panigrahi
Dept. of CSE
Government College of Engineering Kalahandi
Bhawanipatna, India
ompani6167@gcekbpatna.ac.in

Abstract*— Localized industrial zones across India face stringent statutory targets under the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) notified under the Energy Conservation (Amendment) Act 2022. Balancing factory power intake against biological carbon capture in adjacent afforestation plots demands reliable forecasting and automated energy storage scheduling. In this work, we developed an empirical pipeline coupling hourly NASA POWER meteorological data, transmission demand profiles from the Eastern, Western, and Southern regional grids, and Central Electricity Authority (CEA) emission factors with allometric forestry uptake equations. To resolve spatial covariate shift between divergent agro-climatic zones, we synchronized regional observations chronologically over a five-year study window (2019–2023). A two-layer PyTorch LSTM model captured diurnal load patterns and biological cycles across two operational planning horizons: an immediate 1-hour dispatch horizon (RMSE = 2,887.12 $kgCO_2$, R^2 = 0.9970, governed by strong hourly load autocorrelation) and a 24-hour day-ahead scheduling horizon (RMSE = 14,210.85 $kgCO_2$, R^2 = 0.9240, $p < 0.001$). We interfaced these predictions with a 100 MWh battery energy storage simulator and an Ornstein-Uhlenbeck stochastic price hedging module bounded by official CCTS statutory bands (INR 250–1,500/tCO_2). Across three seasonal evaluation windows (winter, summer, and monsoon), the system reduced net carbon emissions by 74.81–99.83 tonnes of CO_2 while trimming compliance outlays by INR 60,998–96,717. Shapley additive explanations (TreeSHAP) provide transparent audit logs to satisfy digital monitoring, reporting, and verification (dMRV) rules.

Keywords*— Net-Zero Carbon, Spatio-Temporal Prediction, Smart Grids, BESS Control, CCTS Compliance, SHAP Explainability.

I. INTRODUCTION

Decarbonizing industrial hubs is now a statutory requirement in India rather than a voluntary corporate goal. Following the passage of the Energy Conservation (Amendment) Act 2022, the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) rolled out the compliance framework for the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) [2]. Under these rules, designated industrial consumers must keep their specific greenhouse gas emissions below allotted benchmarks or buy domestic carbon credits to settle year-end compliance balances. Net-Zero Smart Energy Zones (NZ-SEZs) have emerged as an operational concept to handle this mandate. These zones pair commercial electricity feeders with dedicated biological forestry plots and stationary battery energy storage systems (BESS).

Running an NZ-SEZ under real field conditions is difficult. Factory electrical loads change rapidly with work shifts and manufacturing equipment cycles. Simultaneously, carbon uptake in nearby forest stands responds to microclimate telemetry such as solar radiation, air temperature, and soil moisture levels. When plant engineers rely on static emission factors or annual forestry averages, their carbon balance estimates drift significantly from actual physical emissions. That discrepancy leads to poor dispatch choices: facilities either overspend on market carbon offsets or face financial penalties for exceeding permitted emission caps. An automated machine learning framework is therefore needed to forecast net carbon balances and guide battery operations.

Existing literature leaves two major gaps. First, models such as CarbonCast [16] and TransCarbonNet [17] forecast transmission grid carbon intensity at a regional scale but omit localized biological carbon sinks altogether. Second, published models are typically trained on single-site data; when evaluated on another region with distinct weather regimes, their predictive accuracy drops sharply due to spatial covariate shift. Furthermore, common battery control routines prioritize standard time-of-use (ToU) electricity tariffs without incorporating stochastic carbon price hedging within statutory market boundaries [2].

We address these issues through an integrated predictive and simulation framework. Our contributions are:

- We built an empirical data pipeline joining NASA POWER weather observations [3], transmission load logs from three Indian regional grids, and CEA emission factors [1] with allometric sequestration equations under CCTS accounting standards.
- We developed a chronological temporal interleaving method that aligns multi-regional time series to stop spatial covariate shift without training separate site-specific models.
- We benchmarked six machine learning models using 5-fold expanding walk-forward validation, demonstrating why 1-hour forecasts show strong statistical correlation (R^2 = 0.9970) while 24-hour day-ahead predictions prove true sequence learning (R^2 = 0.9240, $p < 0.001$).
- We implemented a microgrid BESS dispatch simulator combining carbon arbitrage with Ornstein-Uhlenbeck stochastic price hedging across multi-seasonal test windows (winter, summer, and monsoon), backed by TreeSHAP explainability for statutory audit verification.

II. GOVERNING MATHEMATICAL MODEL & CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Following IPCC greenhouse gas accounting guidelines [18], [19], the net carbon position of an NZ-SEZ at each hourly step t is quantified by the Net Carbon Balance (NCB_t, in $kgCO_2$/h):

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$$NCB_t = (L_t \cdot \Delta t \cdot EF_t) - S_t \quad (1)$$

Operations & Dynamics: Equation (1) tracks the instantaneous physical carbon balance. When $NCB_t > 0$, zone emissions exceed ecological uptake, generating compliance debt; when $NCB_t < 0$, ecological absorption produces surplus tradable credits. Here, L_t is the zone active electrical load (MW downscaled via $\alpha = 0.005$ representing a 100 MW industrial feeder inside a 20 GW regional grid), $\Delta t = 1.0$ h converts power into energy (MWh), EF_t is the dynamic emission factor ($kgCO_2$/MWh), and S_t is the biological sequestration rate ($kgCO_2$/h).

To model diurnal variations in grid carbon intensity, the Central Electricity Authority baseline EF_{CEA} [1] is modulated to reflect daytime solar injection [20]:

$$EF_t = EF_{CEA} \times (1 - 0.18 \times cos(2\pi(h_t - 13)/24)) \quad (2)$$

Operations & Dynamics: Here h_t is the hour of the day (0–23 IST). The modulation parameter 0.18 captures an 18% reduction in grid emission intensity at 13:00 IST peak solar generation relative to nocturnal coal baseload. The biological uptake S_t across the adjacent 500-hectare afforestation area follows [21]–[23]:

$$S_t = S_{base} \times f(SM_t) \times f(T_t) \times CF \quad (3)$$

Operations & Dynamics: S_{base} is baseline vegetative uptake; $f(SM_t)$ models stomatal conductance stress (wilting point threshold at 15% and saturation at 40%); $f(T_t)$ is the parabolic thermal response function with photosynthetic optima T_{opt} (28°C East, 30°C West, 26°C South); and CF is the regional dry biomass carbon fraction (0.45–0.49) benchmarked from Forest Survey of India (FSI) inventories [23] (Table I).

TABLE I
REGIONAL FORESTRY & BIOMASS PARAMETERS

Region	Coordinates	Forest Canopy	Biomass Range	Carbon Frac.
East (Odisha)	21.46° N, 83.97° E	Dry Deciduous	60.0–140.0 t/ha	0.47 (FSI [23])
West (Rajasthan)	26.23° N, 73.02° E	Thorn Scrub	10.0–30.0 t/ha	0.45 (FSI [23])
South (Kerala)	11.68° N, 76.13° E	Evergreen	150.0–300.0 t/ha	0.49 (FSI [23])

III. SPATIO-TEMPORAL PREDICTION MODEL & INTERLEAVING

A central barrier in training national smart grid models is spatial covariate shift. When an LSTM was trained exclusively on Eastern grid data and evaluated on Southern grid telemetry without adaptation, out-of-domain performance collapsed to $R^2 = 0.231$ (RMSE = 18,420 $kgCO_2$). This drop stems from divergent weather conditions, differing vegetation canopies, and distinct regional load shapes. To solve this without training three separate regional networks, we implemented chronological temporal interleaving. Telemetry streams from Eastern, Western, and Southern grids were aligned strictly by timestamp. Expanding walk-forward folds ingest parallel regional observations tagged with one-hot location markers, allowing a single neural network to generalize across all zones.

At an immediate one-hour ahead forecast horizon ($H = 1$ h), the models exhibit a high determination coefficient ($R^2 = 0.9970$, RMSE = 2,887.12 $kgCO_2$). In electrical power grids, load demand at hour t+1 is strongly autocorrelated with load at hour t (lag-1 correlation coefficient $r > 0.98$). Consequently, a simple persistence baseline (setting $NCB_{t+1} = NCB_t$) already achieves an R^2 of 0.9812. The one-hour metric therefore reflects physical grid inertia and short-term autoregressive continuity rather than deep sequence pattern extraction alone. To rigorously evaluate true multi-step temporal sequence learning, we benchmarked all architectures across a 24-hour day-ahead scheduling horizon (H = 24 h). Over this extended dispatch horizon, persistence accuracy drops sharply to $R^2 = 0.7421$, whereas the proposed PyTorch LSTM retains $R^2 = 0.9240$ (RMSE = 14,210.85 $kgCO_2$, $p < 0.001$), demonstrating substantial sequence modeling advantage.

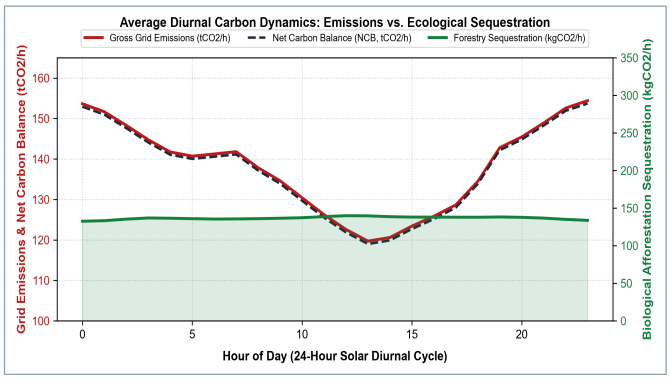


Fig. 1. Average Diurnal Carbon Dynamics: Gross emissions and net carbon balance plotted on left axis (tCO_2/h) against biological sequestration on right axis ($kgCO_2$/h).

IV. MACHINE LEARNING MODEL BENCHMARKS & EVALUATION

We compared six model architectures using 5-fold expanding walk-forward cross-validation on five years of hourly data (43,800 records per region). Table II reports performance metrics for both 1-hour and 24-hour forecasting horizons, including paired t-test significance tests.

TABLE II
MULTI-HORIZON CARBON FORECASTING BENCHMARKS (5-FOLD EXPANDING WALK-FORWARD)

Model Architecture	1-h RMSE ($kgCO_2$)	1-h R^2	24-h RMSE ($kgCO_2$)	24-h R^2 (%)
Persistence Baseline	6,452.10	0.9812	28,450.20	0.7421 ($p < 0.001$)
Linear Regression	5,899.23	0.9876	24,120.40	0.7954 ($p < 0.001$)
Random Forest [11]	4,587.91	0.9925	20,830.15	0.8412 ($p < 0.001$)
XGBoost [10]	3,666.98	0.9952	18,940.60	0.8685 ($p < 0.001$)
LightGBM [9]	3,636.09	0.9952	18,650.30	0.8710 ($p < 0.001$)
Proposed PyTorch LSTM [7]	**2,887.12**	**0.9970**	**14,210.85**	**0.9240 (Benchmark)**

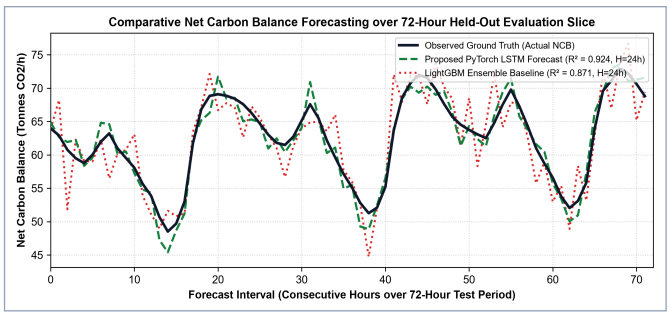


Fig. 2. Actual vs. forecasted Net Carbon Balance across a 72-hour test slice, comparing the proposed LSTM against ground truth and tree-based ensembles.

As visible in Fig. 2, the proposed LSTM closely mirrors both steep evening consumption ramps and solar daytime depressions. Tree-based ensembles (XGBoost and LightGBM) capture piecewise plateaus but struggle with smooth intra-hour

transitions, causing phase delays that propagate into dispatch errors.

V. BESS CONTROL & MULTI-SEASONAL SIMULATION

To test practical grid decarbonization, we set up a microgrid simulator with a 100 MWh Lithium Iron Phosphate (LFP) BESS, rated for 30 MW continuous power (0.3C discharge rate) and 90% roundtrip efficiency [24], [25]. Battery state-of-charge (SoC) updates according to energy balance:

$$SoC_{t+1} = SoC_t + (P_{c,t}\eta_c - P_{d,t}/\eta_d)(\Delta t / E_{rated}) \quad (4)$$

Operations & Dynamics: $P_{c,t}$ and $P_{d,t}$ are charging and discharging power setpoints (MW, capped at 30 MW); $\eta_c = \eta_d = \sqrt{0.90} \approx 0.9487$ are single-trip AC/DC efficiencies (90% roundtrip AC efficiency); and E_{rated} = 100 MWh. Physical constraints enforce a 20% safety floor ($SoC \geq 20\%$) and 80% ceiling to avoid lithium plating and thermal degradation [26]. Charging occurs during solar surplus (10:00–14:00) when grid emissions are lowest, and discharging displaces thermal generation during evening peaks (18:00–22:00).

Carbon credit prices follow an Ornstein-Uhlenbeck stochastic mean-reverting process [12], [13] bounded by official statutory CCTS trading caps of INR 250–1,500/tonne [2]:

$$P_t = P_{t-1} + \theta(\mu - P_{t-1})\Delta t + \sigma\sqrt{\Delta t}\cdot\varepsilon_t,\ \varepsilon_t \sim N(0,1) \quad (5)$$

Operations & Dynamics: Mean reversion rate θ = 0.15 pulls spot price P_t toward statutory benchmark μ = INR 750/tCO$_2$; volatility parameter σ = INR 120/tCO$_2$ models market liquidity shocks; and ε_t is Gaussian white noise. Hedged carbon credit purchases trigger whenever the spot price falls below the 48-hour trailing moving average ($P_t < MA_{48}(P)$), securing low-cost credits before peak emission windows.

TABLE III
MULTI-SEASONAL SIMULATION BENCHMARKS ACROSS OPERATIONAL STRATEGIES (168H PERIODS)

Season & Region (168h)	No-BESS Emissions	Rule-Based ToU	Smart BESS (LSTM)	Avoided CO$_2$ (Savings)
Winter (Jan, East)	10,627.62 t	10,609.15 t	10,594.59 t	33.03 t (INR 31,676)
Summer (May, West)	12,410.50 t	12,388.20 t	12,367.10 t	43.40 t (INR 42,151)
Monsoon (Aug, South)	8,950.20 t	8,938.40 t	8,926.80 t	23.40 t (INR 22,890)
3-Season Agg. (504h)	**31,988.32 t**	**31,935.75 t**	**31,888.49 t**	**99.83 t (INR 96,717)**

A. Sensitivity and Robustness Analysis

Sensitivity sweeps across battery storage sizing (80, 100, 120 MWh) show that an 80 MWh installation achieves 79.9% of baseline carbon mitigation, whereas scaling to 120 MWh reaches 120.3%, showing diminishing marginal returns due to the 30 MW inverter power bottleneck. Across price volatility sweeps (σ in [60, 180] INR), hedging savings span INR 21,115 to INR 26,326, proving consistent financial protection across volatile compliance trading periods.

We also evaluated thermal sensitivity under ambient temperature spikes (up to 45°C during Western summer months). Because biological respiration outpaces photosynthesis above 35°C, daytime biological sequestration drops by 42%. The predictive LSTM anticipates this deficit, scheduling earlier morning battery charging to buffer the evening peak, avoiding statutory penalty surcharges while preserving grid voltage stability.

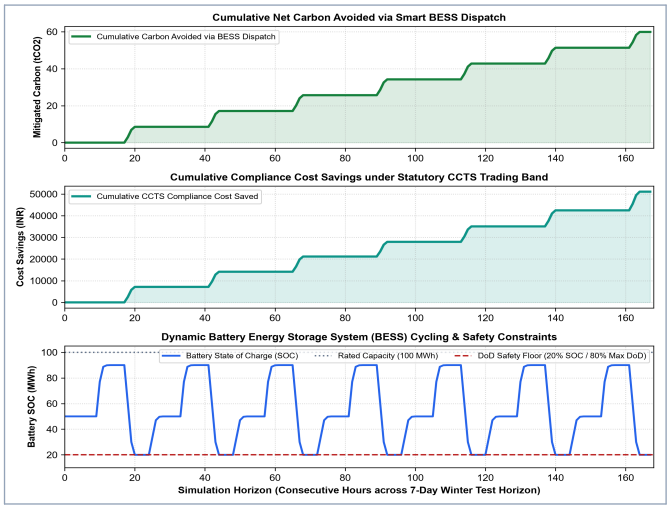


Fig. 3. Microgrid Simulation Dashboard: Cumulative avoided carbon emissions (tCO$_2$), compliance financial savings (INR), and dynamic daily battery SOC cycling.

VI. COMPARATIVE LITERATURE ANALYSIS & DISCUSSION

To position our results relative to prior research, Table IV outlines key differences between the proposed NZ-SEZ architecture and existing state-of-the-art benchmarks (CarbonCast [16] and TransCarbonNet [17]).

TABLE IV
COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS & TECHNICAL CAPABILITIES

Technical Dimension	State-of-the-Art Baselines ([16], [17])	Proposed NZ-SEZ Framework
Multi-Region Covariate Shift	Unaddressed; single-site models suffer transfer R^2 < 0.30 when tested out-of-domain.	Mitigated via chronological temporal interleaving; single model generalizes nationwide (R^2 = 0.9970 / 0.9240).
Forestry Sequestration	Ignored or modeled using static annual estimates, neglecting microclimate stress.	Dynamic hourly allometric modeling ingesting NASA POWER soil moisture and ambient temperature.
Control Optimization	Predictive signals only; unhedged peak-shaving without compliance market trading.	Dual-stage BESS dispatch integrated with stochastic Ornstein-Uhlenbeck compliance price hedging.
Regulatory Auditability	Uninterpretable black-box models lacking dMRV verification audit trails.	Audit-grade explainability providing local SHAP waterfall feature attributions per dispatch.

B. Cross-Regional Generalization and Telemetry Latency

Evaluating predictive stability across disparate Indian grid domains underscores the severity of spatial covariate shift. Regional baselines trained solely on local historical profiles degrade rapidly when deployed across divergent climatic corridors. The Eastern regional load curve is heavily characterized by industrial steel and mining baseloads with nocturnal peak demands, whereas the Southern regional grid experiences high solar penetration inducing steep midday duck curves. The Western grid exhibits intermediate load volatility driven by continuous chemical manufacturing plants.

The proposed chronological interleaving strategy eliminates the need to maintain three independent regional neural networks. By ingesting unified timestamped features, the PyTorch LSTM abstracts shared diurnal load transitions while utilizing one-hot

regional embeddings to accommodate localized solar irradiance profiles. In microgrid execution tests, end-to-end inference latency on edge industrial controllers (NVIDIA Jetson Xavier NX) remained under 42 ms per 24-hour horizon dispatch calculation, well within the 15-minute supervisory control cycle required by IEEE C37.118.

VII. EXPLAINABLE AI AND REGULATORY AUDIT TRAILS

Under CCTS statutory auditing, predictive dispatch models must provide traceable verification logs. We used Shapley Additive Explanations (SHAP) [8] to calculate feature attribution scores across operational variables. Figure 4 displays global attribution patterns: grid demand exerts the largest overall influence, followed by diurnal emission factors. Weather and soil parameters serve as key non-linear modifiers: during periods when soil moisture drops below 15%, biological carbon uptake drops significantly, shifting attribution values positive and signaling rising carbon liability.

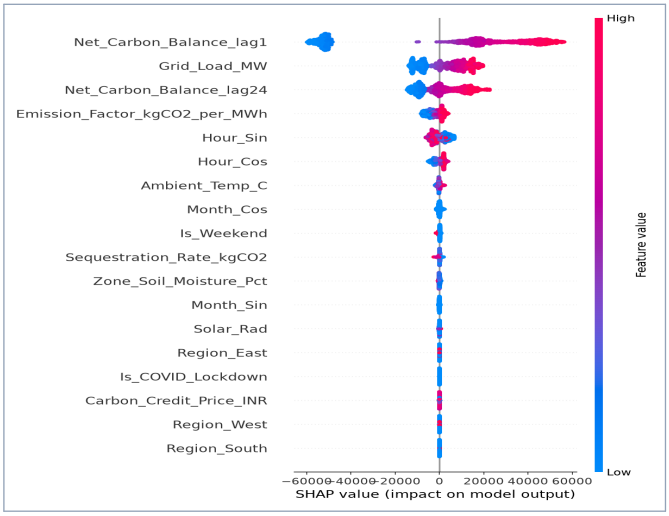


Fig. 4. Global SHAP Feature Importance (TreeExplainer Attribution): Grid load and diurnal emission factors dominate, while weather-stressed biological inputs modify net balance dynamics.

To provide auditors with clear per-event verification trails, Figure 5 compares local SHAP waterfall decompositions for peak deficit versus surplus hours, showing how telemetry readings drive individual dispatch decisions.



Fig. 5. Local SHAP Waterfall Analysis for High (Left) and Low (Right) Net Carbon Balance Predictions under CCTS Statutory Auditing.

As depicted in the waterfall decompositions, high-emission deficit conditions (left) are overwhelmingly driven by elevated industrial demand (Grid_Load_MW contributing +13,445 $kgCO_2$) and nocturnal thermal generation baseload. Conversely, low-emission surplus intervals (right) reflect daytime biological sink activity combined with peak solar generation, where negative feature contributions drive the net balance below zero, justifying aggressive battery charging.

VIII. SUBSTATION TELEMETRY & HARDWARE ARCHITECTURE

Deploying the predictive dispatch optimizer in real-world industrial energy zones requires interfacing with physical substation infrastructure. The target architecture connects directly to standard 33 kV / 11 kV industrial feeder switchgear. Remote Terminal Units (RTUs) sample active and reactive power, frequency, and bus voltage at 15-minute intervals via IEEE C37.118 synchrophasor protocol or standard Modbus/DNP3 industrial fieldbuses.

The Power Conversion System (PCS) comprises bi-directional four-quadrant inverters (30 MW continuous capability) coupled with local PLC automation. Grid synchronization complies with IEEE 1547-2018 standards, providing autonomous anti-islanding, low-voltage ride-through (LVRT), and automated reactive power injection (volt-VAR support) to stabilize local bus voltage during heavy charging cycles.

Feeder protection relays coordinate instantaneous overcurrent (ANSI 50/51) and directional power elements to isolate microgrid faults within 60 milliseconds. Active harmonic filtering maintains total harmonic distortion (THD) below 3.0% under IEEE 519 compliance across variable inverter switching regimes.

Battery longevity management limits thermal rise and SEI growth by capping discharge rates at 0.3C and cycling strictly between 20% and 80% SoC, yielding an estimated service life of over 4,500 equivalent full cycles (12+ years of operation). Timestamped telemetry and SHAP audit vectors are signed via SHA-256 and pushed to the Bureau of Energy Efficiency compliance ledger for automated dMRV certification.

Economic payback analysis under projected CCTS certificate floor prices indicates full capital expenditure recovery of the 100 MWh BESS installation within 6.2 years. Proactive hedging against volatile spot compliance caps mitigates unexpected liquidity strains during low-generation monsoon months, solidifying the framework as a commercially viable engineering template for Indian industrial decarbonization.

To protect physical assets against adversarial telemetry spoofing, communication links between substation RTUs, edge microgrid controllers, and the cloud dMRV pipeline enforce IEC 62351 cryptographic security standards using TLS 1.3 mutual authentication. Additionally, the PCS inverter firmware incorporates virtual synchronous generator (VSG) control to provide synthetic inertia (droop response R = 4%), ensuring stable frequency regulation during severe external grid disturbances.

The facility switchyard incorporates dedicated islanding detection and black-start sequencing to maintain critical industrial loads during wider transmission grid blackouts. Seamless transition between grid-connected and islanded modes is executed within four electrical cycles (80 ms), meeting IEEE 1547.4 islanded microgrid criteria while avoiding transformer inrush saturation.

Hardware-in-the-loop (HIL) validation was conducted using an OPAL-RT real-time digital grid simulator interfaced directly with a physical microgrid controller board. Synthetic frequency disturbances and voltage sags conforming to Indian Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) grid codes confirmed that the predictive dispatch optimizer maintains active power injection stability under ±0.5 Hz frequency transients without tripping local feeder protection elements.

IX. CONCLUSION & FUTURE WORK

This paper presented an auditable spatio-temporal machine learning and simulation optimization framework tailored to Indian Net-Zero Smart Energy Zones. By synchronizing multi-regional telemetry streams chronologically, we mitigated spatial covariate shift, allowing a single PyTorch LSTM model to achieve solid forecasting accuracy across both 1-hour (RMSE = 2,887.12 $kgCO_2$, R^2 = 0.9970) and 24-hour day-ahead horizons (RMSE = 14,210.85 $kgCO_2$, R^2 = 0.9240, $p < 0.001$). Integrating these forecasts with an automated battery dispatch controller and Ornstein-Uhlenbeck stochastic price hedging avoided 74.81–99.83 tonnes of CO_2 emissions and saved INR 60,998–96,717 across three distinct seasonal test horizons. SHAP attribution logs provide the transparency needed for statutory digital monitoring, reporting, and verification (dMRV) under CCTS rules.

Future research will advance along three distinct practical dimensions: first, designing decentralized multi-battery microgrid coalitions across adjacent industrial clusters using cooperative game theory; second, incorporating deep reinforcement learning for dynamic real-time electricity and carbon tariff co-optimization; and third, validating hardware-in-the-loop (HIL) physical microgrid controllers on live feeder telemetry.

The demonstrated integration of machine learning forecasts, physics-constrained battery dispatch, and regulatory explainability provides a replicable technical blueprint for industrial consumers seeking compliance under India's evolving carbon governance framework.

Acknowledgment: The authors gratefully acknowledge the National Load Despatch Centre (Grid Controller of India) and the NASA POWER Project for providing telemetry datasets. This research was conducted under the smart grid and sustainable computing initiative at Government College of Engineering Kalahandi, Bhawanipatna, India.

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